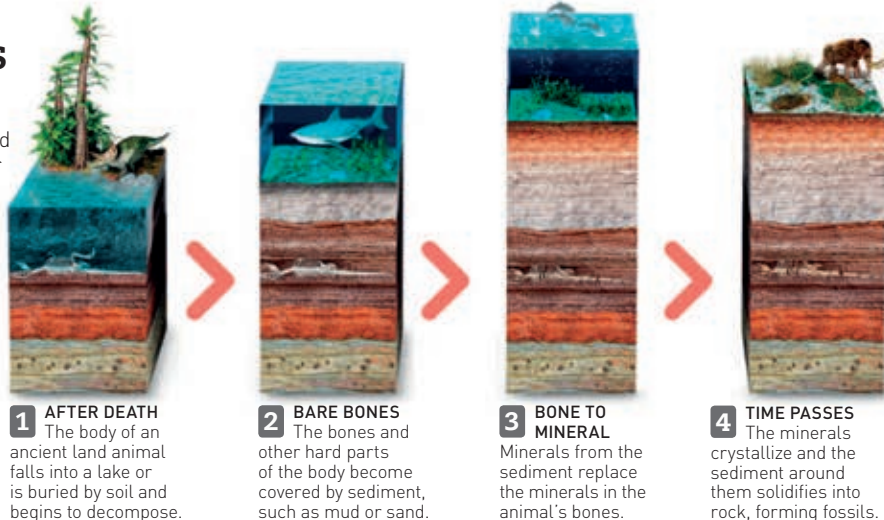


Fossils

Fossils are clues preserved in rocks, amber (tree resin), tar, or ice. They show us what plants and animals looked like thousands or millions of years ago and can sometimes tell us where and how they lived.

HOW FOSSILS FORM

Fossils form when a plant or animal is buried quickly and deeply after it dies. The sediment that surrounds the animal gradually turns its body into rock over thousands of years. This is called fossilization.



PLANTS

Fossil plants are usually fossils of parts of the plant, rather than the whole thing. They include leaves, flowers, cones, bark, and wood.



CALCIFIED ALGAE STEM



LIQUIDAMBAR LEAF



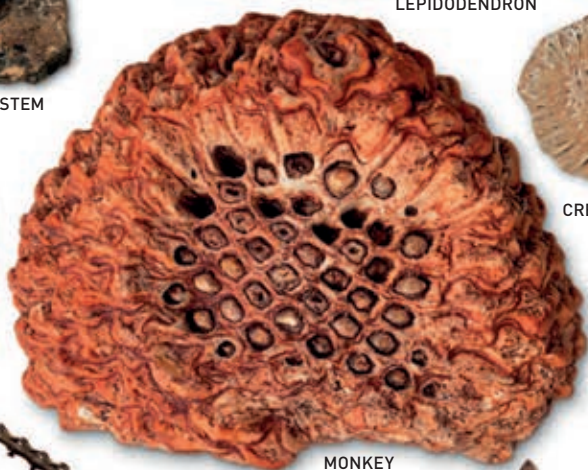
SEED FERN LEAFLETS



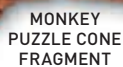
LEPIDODENDRON



TREE TRUNK



CRETACEOUS CONE



MONKEY PUZZLE CONE FRAGMENT



PTERIDOSPERM SEEDS



PECTOPTERIS MILTONI FROND



TECTOCARYA SEEDS

INVERTEBRATES

Fossils of animals without backbones have been found in large numbers and from a wide range of animal types.



BRYOZOAN



AMMONITE



HORN CORAL



ACTINOCYATHUS CORAL



LITHOSTROTION CORAL



SEA PEN



SPIDER TRAPPED IN AMBER



BRAIN CORAL



TRILOBITE



COCKROACH



CLAM SHELL



SEA LILY



LACE CORAL



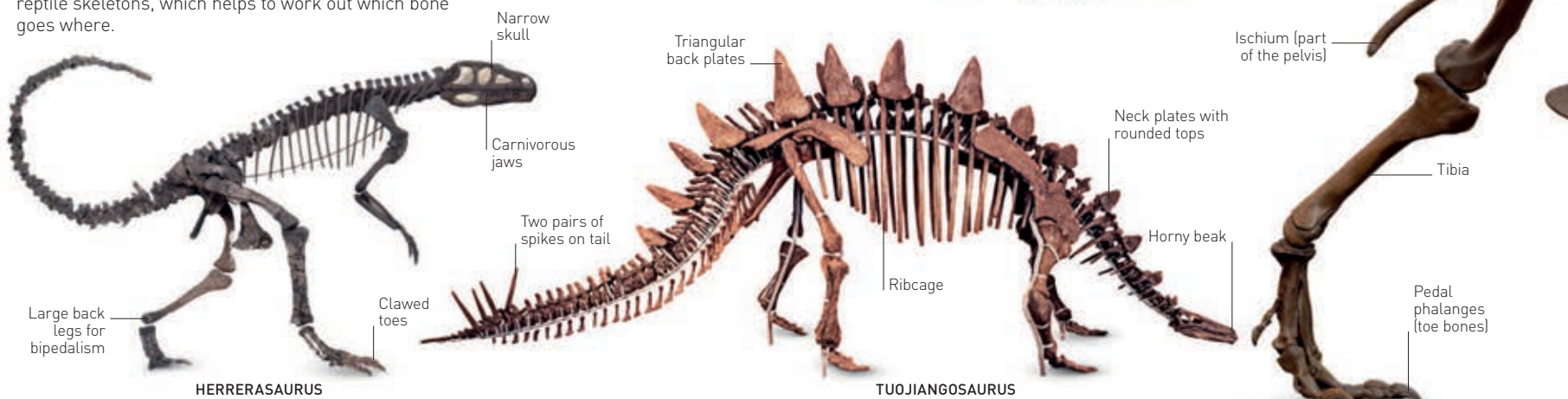
SEA SNAIL SHELL



HEART URCHIN

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Dinosaur bones can be found scattered over a large area and scientists then work out how they are pieced together. Dinosaur skeletons are very like bird and reptile skeletons, which helps to work out which bone goes where.



HERRERASAURUS

TUOJIANGOSAURUS

Narrow skull

Carnivorous jaws

Two pairs of spikes on tail

Clawed toes

Triangular back plates

Ribcage

Neck plates with rounded tops

Horny beak

Ischium (part of the pelvis)

Tibia

Pedal phalanges (toe bones)